

THE TRAPPED MONKEY

- Ramasamy Rathnam



Six Short Stories

**Dedicated to the
Inner Guru
Who has no name and no form**

THE TRAPPED MONKEY

by

Ramasamy Rathnam

Copyright 2026 © Ramasamy Rathnam

contact email address: shikhaimages@outlook.com

Title of book: **The Trapped Monkey**

Author: **Ramasamy Rathnam**

ISBN: **978-93-6123-433-0**

First edition **19-07-2026**

The contents of this digital book, both text and images, are free to copy and use for all purposes.

The entire text was written by the author who is human.

Stories were not conceived or written by AI (Artificial Intelligence).

One quote from Khalil Gibran has been used in the last story.

The stories are imaginary and fictional and do not represent any living persons.

All images are representative only. All images except the front cover were created by **Gemini**, and its **AI (Artificial Intelligence)** image generation tool. Cover Image alone was created by **Copilot** and its **AI** imaging tool.

The digital copy of this book is distributed free. இந்த டிஜிட்டல் நூலில் பதிவு ஆகி இருக்கும் படங்கள் மற்றும் தகவல், செய்திகள் கதைகள் படங்கள் அனைத்தும் Public Domain. காபிரைட் அனுமதி தேவை இல்லை . எல்லா படங்களும் Gemini AI Tools மூலமாக உருவாக்கப்பட்டன. அட்டை படம் மட்டும் Copilot மூலமாக உருவாக்கப்பட்டது.

The image on the front cover

The lotus, Buddha and the peacock represent enlightenment, evolved souls and the higher states of consciousness. The monkey and the trapped hand reflect the state of humans drowned in "samasara" or worldliness. The monkey can pull out the hand if it drops the banana, which is desire after material wealth, power and fame.

Contents

[Dog Mother](#)
[Turn your attention!](#)
[The Departure](#)
[Tara and Sarah](#)
[RolePlay](#)
[The only real friend](#)

Dog Mother.....	6
Turn your attention!.....	11
The Departure.....	12
Tara and Sarah.....	15
RolePlay.....	22
The only real friend.....	25

Dog Mother

This story happened in a small village just on the outskirts of Kollam in Kerala during the latter half of the year 2020. That was when the whole world was struggling because of the pandemic COVID-19. The village was close enough to the city to get modern services and still staying away from the din and bustle of a city. It had simple people, good sea breeze, and green trees everywhere. The best fresh fish was available in the local markets.

It was essentially a retirees' haven. Nanaji was one of the natives who worked in Mumbai for three decades and returned to settle in his village after retirement. His actual name was Narayanan and that was shortened to "Nanaji" in Mumbai. Nanaji also meant 'grandfather' in Hindi and he too liked it. The name got stuck and came along to his own native place also. Now he is nearing 80 years of age.

Nanaji spent most of his working years in the accounting system. The principles of accounting got into his blood and probably into his DNA too. He will do everything needed to balance the books with integrity. No data can escape his sharp eyes. He had a kind side also. He will not accept an extra rupee from any customer above the published price. Any extra amount from anyone will be paid back promptly. He also made sure all his bills were paid as early as possible and not on the last day. He believed that late payment means the amount owed reduces in value and that was dishonesty!

Nanaji's world was always like that. The equation has to be perfectly balanced always. In his world no one can dare to charge even one rupee more. The bill and actual money collected has to be a hundred percent the same. Even his family members used to get upset at times. "At times you are an ATM machine; at times you are a POS machine" - this was a pet peeve from his family.

Nanaji will never exploit anyone, but he will make sure the rules are followed. Every item should be paid by the displayed price list. In his world when someone overcharges it means they are cheating. Even human errors were forgiven only after an explanation.

Nanaji's family had a pet dog called Jimmy. Every morning it was Nanaji's task to take Jimmy out for a walk. Jimmy would mark his territories, then poop, sniff the air for some time and return. During these times there was a shut-down and people did not come out normally. Even the dogs that lived by scavenging had a tough time finding food.



One of them was a female dog that had littered recently. Nanaji noticed her and felt pity. He fed her every morning with three or four biscuits. He will also tap her gently on the forehead. Within 2 weeks the puppies also came out of their shelter along with their mother. Slowly the puppies also learnt to eat biscuits. This dog always insisted on taking the biscuits from Nanaji's hands. She will not touch anything that falls on the ground and those pieces were eaten by her puppies. One of the puppies was quite aggressive; it used to snatch even the piece in her mother's jaws. The mother dog happily allowed to drop the food in her jaw to her own puppy.

Nanaji observed all these and this was new to him - street dogs and how they raised their puppies. During one of his dog walks, Nanaji came across a stranded puppy. Barely a couple of weeks old and its eyes still not open completely, the puppy was left abandoned at a street corner. Nanaji brought it home and tried to save it. Because of the pandemic and the shutdown he could not get the help from rescue organisations. Alas! The puppy died in his own hands by the end of the fourth day. Over these four days Nanaji learnt from his friends and neighbours - that nothing is comparable to mother's milk for any newborn - human or dog or cat or any mammal.

Mother Nature has put everything there - a complete diet with its own medicines and tonics needed for the young one. The cow milk cannot be given to these puppies. The only thing that can be fed is clean warm water with a little glucose. "The puppies can digest only its own mother's milk or this sweet glucose water" - he was told. Nanaji also went through the exercise of cleaning the puppies plate with hot water several times a day. He said to himself "Being a mother is not easy, old man!".

The female dog showed its gratitude to Nanaji. During his dog walks the mother dog will escort him and Jimmy led in the front. One day Nanaji saw the mother dog eating human excreta lying on the roadside. Probably she was very hungry that day. But it was an unclean act. In Nanaji's world these are punishable acts! He did not feed the female dog for a day to show his displeasure. The mother dog saw Nanaji walking fast without looking at her and without offering the biscuits. Her eyes were blank but she understood.

The same evening Nanaji spoke to his auditor on the money that came as income from his investment in mutual funds. The income had reduced because of COVID-19 effects on the stock market. The return of investment or "**ROI**" as it is called, was low. Nanaji was worried and he was thinking over it after his dinner. **ROI, ROI** the words were repeating in his mind aimlessly.

A dog barked at a distant house and Nanaji's mind changed tracks.

Nanaji thought about the hapless mother dog and her puppies with nobody to look after and the way the dog ate the human faeces. As he was thinking about it, it suddenly dawned on him that the mother dog had to eat faeces not for her survival but for her puppies' survival.

Rain or shine the production of mother's milk cannot stop for any reason. Survival of species depends on the survival of newborns and younger members of the species. The raw material for the milk production is dependent on the food that the mother dog eats!

The accounting mind of Nanaji started ringing "**ROI, ROI**" again. And then something wonderful happened! Nanaji wondered what is the **ROI** for this milk production. The mother dog ingested human excreta - most unwanted stuff that is difficult to dispose of. And what did she produce? Mother's milk!

Milk - something that cannot be replaced even by laboratories -

Milk - which is the only thing the puppies can digest -

Milk - that will protect the newborns from most diseases -

Milk that is invaluable, priceless, and not available in the free market!

Input was the worst and cheapest material.

Output was the best and most valuable beyond any price! Even “most expensive” cannot describe it.

Nanaji thought over the sequence again and now he started sweating. “Ende Amme!” (My mother!) He exclaimed a couple of times. Now he remembered his own late mother, and how she showered love on him and his siblings and how she fed everyone with the meagre income of his father. Tears rolled down his cheek. He muttered “ende amme! ende amme!” My mother!

The next morning Nanaji left hurriedly for the dog walk with Jimmy to feed the mother dog. She was there as usual and she wagged her tail happily to receive a full packet of biscuits and his customary tap on the forehead. She understood the old man was friendly again.

On the second day, Nanaji could not see the mother dog. She was missing. And the day after that also. She was not seen at all from that day. Maybe she died somewhere or she was taken away by someone. But she left a vacuum in Nanaji’s daily life. For nearly three months, she was a part of his life. Nanaji felt guilty and wished he had this wisdom much earlier. He would have taken better care of the dog family.

After the disappearance of mother dog, Nanaji addressed her as ‘dog mother’. When Mrs. Nanaji demanded an explanation, he gave a long explanation.

“If you say mother dog like mother cat, mother elephant, etcetera you stress on dog, cat, or elephant. The role of mother comes only after that. First it is an animal. Then it is a mother.

But in my view and in my experience motherhood comes first. First it is the mother and then it is an animal. When you say mother dog you are referring to a dog that became a mother by Nature. When you say dog mother your stress is on mother and only after that on the form - like dog, monkey or elephant.” Mrs Nanaji could not understand fully. But she sensed a positive change had happened in her husband.

Life was not the same after that. The Nanaji couple visited many temples and churches of the divine mother. His philosophy changed and "Give more than what you get" became the guiding force in the world of Nanaji. His life-long material scale with money in one plate got shattered. In the new weighing scale of Nanaji, money disappeared permanently. It tilted in favour of material that he gave to others. In Nanaji’s new scale, the plate which contained what he gave was always heavier and went down. Oh! The word **ROI** also disappeared.

Nanaji’s son and his daughter arrived with their families during the Onam festival. His son was working in Singapore and his daughter lived in Dubai. There was no great need of money for them. He wrote his Will with the consent from his wife and both the children. The family decided to donate a 5 acre land - an ancestral property to build a primary health centre with labour wards in his own village. There was a long pending dispute for another property with his first cousin. Nanaji

and his son visited this cousin's family one fine day and just gave away that property. His cousin was not well-to-do and he was only too happy to receive it. He wanted to know what prompted the change but Nanaji kept quiet.

About six months later Nanaji had a vivid dream. In that dream he saw Divine Mother in resplendent beauty and vibrant colours. The vision was more vivid and more intense than real life. There were no words spoken. But Mother was full of life. She walked gently towards Nanaji, gave the most beautiful smile he had ever seen. Mother's eyes overflowed with maternal love for Nanaji. When Nanaji woke up it took a few minutes to return to the normal world. He felt as if he had taken a bath in a holy river and was sitting in a temple. His whole being felt energised and sanctified. He could remember every little thing after the dream. He wrote it down in his diary. This dream made him a little more silent and withdrawn. But essentially a fulfillment came upon him and he wanted nothing more in life. His wife Mrs. Nanaji observed all these changes and could sense something different. She did not worry but helped him in every possible way.

A few weeks after this on a certain festival day in the evening, Nanaji and Mrs. Nanaji were sitting in the hall. Nanaji suddenly exclaimed "ende amme!" (My mother) and collapsed on his charukasera (traditional easy chair) itself. Nanaji departed this world probably with Divine Mother leading him. Maybe the dog mother too came along to escort him on his final journey.

Turn your attention!

The theatre was full! All the tickets for the show were sold out. It was a thriller movie and already had received very good reviews. John and his wife were watching the movie with great interest. Their favourite movie stars were cast in this movie. At times the entire audience was sitting holding their breath and on the edge of their seats the plot was really captivating. the entire audience in the movie.

All of a sudden, John felt a quick but firm slap on his neck. He turned angrily at the person sitting right behind him. That man leaned forward and said politely apologetically "Sir please put your wallet in your front pocket". John removed the wallet from his back trousers pocket and put it in his shirt pocket. His anger did not vanish but he silently complied. John was more interested in watching the movie than in an argument with a stranger.

After the show was over, while walking in the lobby the same man came up to John and politely said, "Sorry Sir! The man next to me was trying to steal your wallet. I tried to draw your attention but you were too engrossed in the movie. So I had to slap your back". Now John understood what happened and thanked him profusely . He cannot afford to lose his credit card during the holiday season.

As he cranked his car engine, he noticed an old lady opening the door of the car next to him. She was talking loudly to the driver waiting for her - probably her son or nephew. "Thank you David, for waiting and for being awake! Sometimes I give a slap on the neck to awaken people". As she spoke “.. to awaken people”, she turned and looked at John’s eyes just for a few seconds - a kind look but piercing it was! GURU!

So it is with our miseries. When we refuse to look inside, when we are too engrossed in the outside - the movie shows, we get a slap on the back. The slap is only to wake up and turn our attention inside.

The opening of the car door lit the face of John for a few moments and the words of the lady illuminated his mind for a long time.

The Departure

(An imaginary story on the death of Archimedes)

This was written originally on 11th January 2023. Rewritten on 13-April-2025

It was a movie festival and was a full day event for the public with several movies on the list. Dennis went there out of curiosity since he had never been to such an event. The last film was on the final day of Archimedes, the Greek scientist and inventor. The movie started. The opening scene displayed a beautiful Greek beach and an old man with white hair and beard drawing or scribbling something on the sand. A young soldier walked past and unintentionally walked over one of the drawings. "You fool! Can't you walk with eyes open?" yelled the old man. The well-built soldier drew his sword in rage and silenced the old man forever. The old man was Archimedes. This is just one of the stories on how he died.

The movie went on to imagine further.



As the soul left his body, two Angels husband and wife, appeared to Archimedes. Unlike the youthful looks of angels in pictures we see, these angels looked quite elderly. They were sent to take his soul with dignity to the heavens. On their way they stopped to rest somewhere high in the clouds.

Archimedes was still fuming. “How can this happen to me? A man of knowledge and a teacher - I am! How selflessly I served my country! What kind of divine law is this? Why would a learned old man be killed by a stranger - a soldier?”

The Angel man looked at Archimedes with kindness and understanding. The Angel woman shed tears. After a few moments of silence the Angel man spoke “Listen my dear brother! I have been through a similar departure from earthly life. Can I share something with you only if you permit?”

Archimedes hesitantly nodded in agreement. But for the Emperors, very few would have the courage to advise Archimedes. But now he was willing and receptive.



“Dear brother, this world is only a stage. Each one of us has a role to play. The director of this play decides the timings to start and stop. The director or directrix is God or Mother Goddess.

When the actor forgets or slips on his part, the prompter corrects him or her. If the actor forgets his real nature and continues to act believing he is the character, the director pulls the curtain down. Are you with me, Archi?”

Archimedes nodded his head.

“Your role was over when the war was over. You have played many roles in the past and you will play many roles in the future. This role is just one of them.”

The Angel man spoke more but we have edited for the sake of brevity.

“Now shall we start our journey again?” Angel man asked.

Archimedes nodded his head in acceptance.

The movie was over. Dennis wrote his observations and comments. He exchanged pleasantries and started to leave. As he walked past the exit door, the security guard stopped him. “Your lanyard sir!”.

For a moment Dennis blinked out of ignorance. Then he realised what she was saying and removed the lanyard and name tag from his neck. He handed them over to the security guard. She smiled and said, “Sometimes we tend to forget, to drop our roles after the play. Don't we? “

For one moment they looked at each other directly in the eyes.

Her eyes were bright, shining and friendly.

GURU!

Tara and Sarah

Far away from the din and bustle of crowded cities and far away from the spiritual town of Rishikesh lies Gangotri, the birthplace of the holy Ganga river in the Himalayan region. Sometime during July-August the rainy season starts. It was one of those days.

Dark clouds had formed across the skies touching the peaks of mountains of Himalayas.

In the dark clouds there were many many droplets. They were clean, pure and faultless like pearls in the oysters. Two of the dark clouds gently elbowed each other. Each cloud gave an angry look at the other. That electrifying look became a spontaneous lightening.

They started yelling at each other that became several roaring Thunders. The sounds struck the nearby mountains and echoed and reverberated.

In one second or even less, the anger gave way to repentance and compassion.

All the emotions turned into watery tears of both the clouds. The tears became

blessings to Mother Earth below waiting for their timely arrival to feed all her children – plants, trees, animals and humans.

It started raining heavily! It continued to rain even after the sunset.

Two droplets - children of the same cloud journeyed together.

One was wise and calm. She was Tara.

And the other droplet was brash and ignorant. She was Sarah.

They fell on the Himalayan peaks on a cold wintery night.

"Oh no, we have to join the rocks and trees!" said Sarah!

"I lived high in the clouds overlooking the whole earth untouched by the mud and dirt."

"Divine Mother has a purpose for everything. We have a task to complete. We will know it only after completing it, at the end of journey. " said Tara.

The rains fell on the Himalayan peaks and they formed part of a pristine snow cover.

The mountains felt blessed and thanked Divine Mother.

The people gazed at the peaks in wonder.

Their hearts were cleansed of baser feelings like anger and greed.

Their hearts were filled with joy and gratitude. The mightiness of the snow peaks made the human onlookers feel more humble. Their pride and vanity were trimmed in size.

Tara and Sarah continued to reside there in the new surroundings.

Later the summer arrived, and the ice started melting.

Sarah and Tara were pushed into a rivulet that fell from great heights.

"Oh no! I am dashed on rock after rock, pulled by the hands of a hiding giant. It is terrible!" said Sarah.

"There is the scent of herbs in the water. Smell it and enjoy! For now, let us hop merrily from rock to rock in a joyful exploration", said Tara and she burst into peals of laughter, every time she dashed on a rock.

At times Tara could move a pebble or two and make them roll.



The rivulet was so clear that the floor of rivulet could be seen through its water.

The rivulet rushed through its course at maddening speed like a race car.

A hundred miles later the rivulet joined another bigger stream. The bigger stream was a bit brownish in color and slower.

They joined to make a bigger stream that was light brown in color but still a mountain stream of incredible speed rushing towards the plains.

"What happened? Who are these stranger droplets?"

It became dark around me and the sunlight was not seen. Is this hell?" sighed Sarah.

"Hey fellows" cried Tara and danced with the millions of other new droplets.

Many times, she jumped above the surface like a fish and shouted in glee.

The sounds of the jumping droplets made a musical tune. The sounds could be heard from places very far.

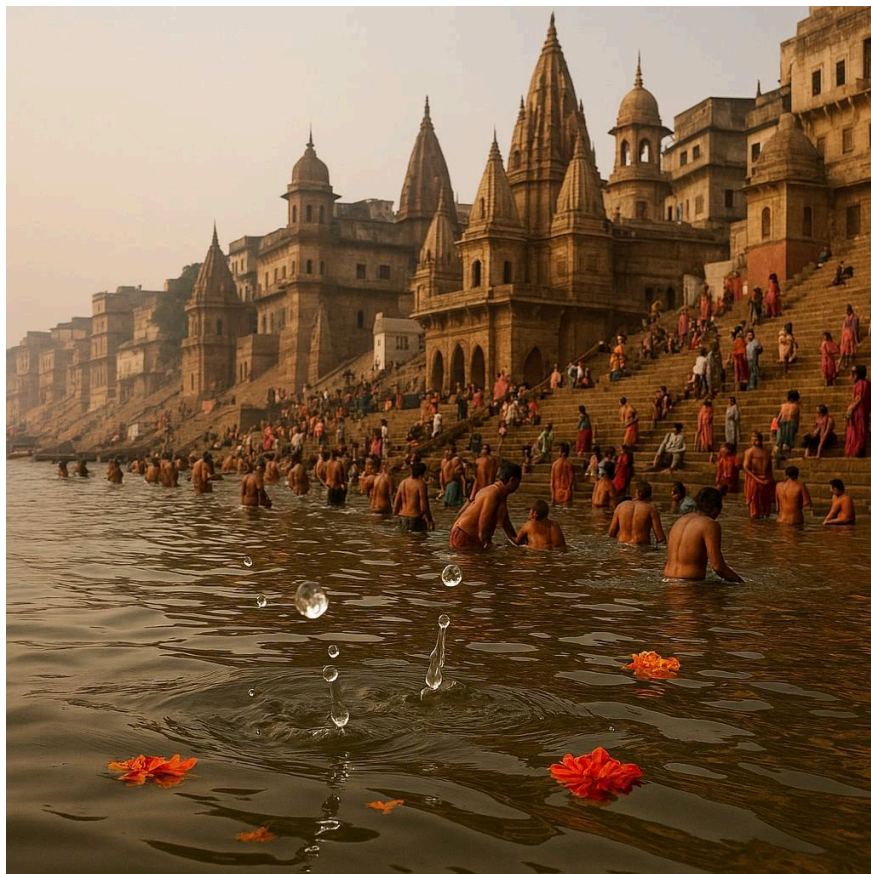
Sometimes the stream flowed between rocks with force and roaring noise like water falling from a big dam.

After crossing several mountains, the stream joined another bigger stream and became the holy river. It is still earthy brown and the speed has reduced but tons of water are moving along. The holy river is grand and so wide that it needs a boat to cross.

"It is too big and scary. The fish keep moving around. It is still dark and muddy. There are humans all around. The scent of the herbs is gone", complained Sarah.

"Humans are doing pilgrimage here. After bath, they pray to Divine Mother. How exciting, we are helping these humans", said Tara.

Still after a few hundred miles, the river touched the holy city. There were hundreds of humans taking bath and praying and fishing. They were also throwing some of the ashes of the dead humans into the water. There were lighted lamps floating in the holy river.



"This is hell on earth. So many people, so much fire and ash, so much waste. I feel offended", cried Sarah.

"They are praying for their own liberation and their forefathers' liberation. We are fortunate to help them speak to the Divine Mother.

Yes, I become a little dirty. But their mind and soul are purified here in this holy river and holy city. I am helping in their progress." said Tara.

The river continued its course. In some places, small streams of wastewater from factories joined it. These gutters were full of filth and garbage. Sarah said "What are they doing? We provide drinking water to the humans. But see the way they are killing us! In fact they are killing their own countrymen who drink the polluted water".

Tara said "Unexpected and unfortunate! They will surely learn and correct themselves soon. Let us help them till that time. As we move over, the dirt will settle down. The men will get purified too and we will make the men worthy of drinking the river water. Let us help them now!"

Finally, the river met the ocean and merged in it. The ocean was an expanse of blue waters without end. There was no shore to be seen. Tara and Sarah dissolved and became one with the ocean.



Sometimes there is an exchange in such meetings and transactions. The clean water helps by providing drinking water and water for trees and fields. The land around in return may give minerals or even herbs to the waters. The soil filters and helps the cleaning. The good and the bad are only temporary and they are based on the perception of the person witnessing. The pure water washes the dirty clothes. The clothes get benefited. What does the water get in return? If water decides to remain without moving, without action, clothes remain dirty and water becomes stagnant and home for bacteria. That is not good for water as well as the clothes. The exchange and the meeting has to happen for a better tomorrow.

Among humans there are good persons and not so good persons. If good persons keep aloof, then there is no influence from one to the other. If wise persons, honest leaders, selfless workers, nuns and monks decide to keep aloof, that society will not benefit. We need role models. We need shock absorbers. We need "sappers" like Swami Vivekananda said - who can remove the mines before the soldiers can march on.

Oh mind! Do not complain about any person walking into our life for any reason. Please learn to accept her or him as she/he is.

Maybe you are the impure water and have to learn something from that person.

Maybe you are the pure water to help that person to become better and evolve.

RolePlay

Written on 24th March 2025

"Keshava! I am so happy to hear your voice. Welcome! welcome! Today we have a performance of Daksha Yagam. You will surely enjoy it".

The speaker over the phone was my childhood friend Balan Nair who pursued his interests in art to become a Kathakali artiste. We are meeting each other after almost 10 years and so it was an important meeting.

Aside, my work situation was hopeless. Well, it was at its deepest lows! The nadir, the lowest ebb will be better words to describe. I had just quit my job on unpleasant terms. The oppressors were coming after my back. Only my faith in my Guru had held me strong against all the storms around me.

Over the phone I agreed to see the Kathakali play and later I will join them for breakfast the next day at his home. That will be ideal for a leisurely chit-chat where we can catch up on our lives so far.

Exactly at 8:00 p.m. in the evening I was present at the theatre, greeted Balan who gave me the VIP seat in the front row. It was a traditional Kathakali performance and had an introductory speech in Malayalam. Something non-traditional was an English talk for about 15 minutes. It was an introduction to the story of the drama, the nuances of the dance and costumes and how to appreciate the movements of the dance.

The performance was simply out of the world! The setting was an evening in the verdant Kerala-rural Kerala. The sounds of Chenda the Kerala drums accompanied the dance all the way to the end. They were ethereal sounds. The story was about the fight between Lord Shiva and King Daksha where Daksha is eventually killed by Lord Shiva.

During the fag end of the play something strange happened. Suresh was the man who took the part of Lord Shiva. On that day, he was in full form - at his best! He took his role very seriously and became one with the character. His fight on the stage was exemplary and his facial expressions were reflecting a divine rage to kill King Daksha.

King Daksha fell down and pretended to be dead. But Suresh did not stop his killer dance. The drummers were slowing down their beats. "Lord Shiva" was supposed to retreat into the side room. But Lord Shiva was refusing to retreat and adamant to fight on! It seemed he may actually stamp the chest of the other dancer and really kill him!



All of a sudden, there was the sound of a long whistle and a colourful curtain was drawn by two men across the stage. It blocked the view of the stage and the actors from the audience. Now two people from the troupe held Suresh (Lord Shiva) tightly and lifted him off the stage to a side-room. In this way the drama ended unexpectedly.

The next morning, I met Balan Nair and his family over a breakfast at his home. It was a traditional breakfast with appam and peanut curry and fried bananas called Pazham Pori. While we were reminiscing and laughing while narrating our old adventures during childhood, Suresh Lord Shiva dropped in.

My friend Balan was Suresh's guru in the Kathakali dance. Suresh apologized profusely for his overacting the previous evening. Balan patiently listened to what Suresh had to say, in private, while I was in the next room.

"These things do happen. Artistes who are committed, do take the role very seriously. So literally their mind does the role a hundred percent. That is commendable.

It is also important that we drop down this role and this mask once the play stops. Completely!

It is all over!

We have no authority to extend our role play. We have to conform to the written script.

When you forget who you are, trouble starts. You identify yourself with the character given to you. But that character is time-bound. When the clock strikes, when the bell rings, if you are not backstage, two strong men will lift you off the stage. They will remind you who you are, by calling your name. They may even pull out your mask by force. It is painful but that is the quickest way for you to remember who you really are!

We also should remember there are better roles to perform in the upcoming dances. Unless we give up the role and all its baggage of emotions at the end of the play, we cannot wear the new mask for the next role! To enter the college, we have to leave the school!"

Suresh listened to his Guru's advice sincerely and left with Balan's blessings.

Balan narrated the whole discussion to his family and myself. Balan's mother jovially remarked, "This is the same Suresh who refused to give up his three wheeled kids' cycle even after growing up. He just needs a little more time".

The same evening I was watching the weekly talk of my favourite spiritual discourse on YouTube. During the talk I was taken aback by these pointers from the monk who spoke.

"You have been hypnotised to believe you are limited!"

"You are not what you take yourself to be!"

I reflected over it a few times. During my evening meditation, these words were heard in my mind-space-

"Guru loves you more than you love Her!. She had to bring the curtains down on your working life. She lifted you physically from centre-stage to the backstage. Only then you can realise who you really are! The course correction is already made. You are walking on the right path. Keep walking and leave everything to Guru!"

From a distant temple, the soft sound of the temple bell was heard.

The only real friend

First written in December 2023

Typed/dictated in February 2026

Time of story: May 1970

Story narrated by : Nanjunda Hegde

Location; Mysuru City, India

Every summer, when the schools are closed for summer vacation, I used to land up at my uncle's house in Mysuru.

The years 1968 to 1972 were eventful and the world was going through major changes, Man landed on the moon, there were anti-war protests in the USA, a major war in the Middle East, and so forth. During the summer of 1970 I met an extra-ordinary man. I took a few learnings that are still fresh in my memory and had a significant impact on my career and personal life. I was only 15 years of age at that time. My uncle and aunt were invited for a dinner along with another family by a local businessman Mr. Krishna Rao. My uncle took me also for the dinner.

The house of Mr. Krishna Rao was a modest one in Yadavagiri area of Mysuru. The house had a big garden around it. There were many flower plants, many of which I saw for the first time. The host Mr. Krishna Rao was a kind old man in his fifties. I always imagined a successful business man would be a commanding personality and would always talk about money and trade most of the time. But Krishna Sir proved it wrong. He discussed what our family members were studying, our health, what books we read, what places we travelled etc. He focused more on each individual in the room. He spoke nothing on wealth and local politics.

The dinner was sumptuous and I experienced the taste of the hospitality of Mysore. Mrs. Rao took great care and served the food herself to all of us. After dinner, about 10 of us sat in the hall chit chatting. Being the only kid, I took the liberty of seeing the photos on the walls around. A particular black and white photograph had an exotic charm about it. I could not take my eyes away from it. There was a beautiful Buddhist Pagoda in the background and about 15 people standing with a Hindu monk seated in the center. The faces were Indian, Chinese and Malay or Burmese.

The host Mr. Krishna Rao noticed my interest in that photograph and came up to me as if he had anticipated a question from me. I asked him,

"Where was this taken, uncle? And is this young man yourself?" pointing to a young person.

"Who is this Swamiji?" This was my next question.

Mr. Krishna Rao said, “The picture was taken in Rangoon (now called as Yangon), the capital of Burma (now called as Myanmar) sometime in 1941. Yes, you could recognize me even though I look much younger in the picture. Swamiji's name is **Rangaswamy Maharaj** and he was in charge of a monastery that did social service and spiritual teachings.

My uncle and others also heard this and my uncle said, “Sir! We too want to know the story on how and why you repatriated from Rangoon. We will also learn a few things from you”.

So, Mr. Krishna Rao sat comfortably on the sofa and narrated his story as it happened in 1941 and 1942. I've tried my best to present that story here.

The Second World War broke out in 1941 and India was still ruled by the colonial powers. The Japanese empire expanded across Asia capturing many sovereign countries. The Japanese Army moved westward along China, Korea, Singapore and Malaysia very fast. Krishna Rao Sir worked and lived in Rangoon and he was only 25 years of age at that time. His parents lived in Puttur near Mangalore, back in India. He was a regular visitor to a monastery run by an Indian monk Rangaswamy Maharaj. They had Gita classes, weekly bhajans and celebrations of festivals and talks. This photograph was taken during Diwali celebration in October or November of 1941 in Rangoon.

By the end of December 1941 the Japanese army crossed the border of Burma. There was no future for Indians in Burma. Life under an occupying army is very tough. In mid-February 1942 Krishna Rao Sir decided to leave Burma. He had to shut down his business and leave things as they were. With a copy of Bhagavad Gita, very little money and a few clothes he started for India by land. There were very few airplanes and ships serving the public because of the war. The only option for him as well as thousands of Indians was to leave by land and reach the northeast part of India. “Leave by land” means leave on foot by walking. There were no buses or public transport in wartime Burma.

The distance from Rangoon to the Indian border in the North was about 1300 kilometers. It took about 15 days to 45 days of walking to reach the Indian border. It all depends on the weather and the health of the person. There were a few dense forests and mountain regions to cross. Entire families with small babies as well as elderly people were also part of the fleeing crowds. It is said about 5 lakhs people (half a million) returned from Burma to India along the land routes in that period. There are no records of deaths. It is estimated about 20 to 30 thousand people were dead along the route. When anyone died, the body was buried by the side of the road if possible. In dense forests, dead bodies were left to rot.



During the journey they saw many people dying due to malaria and dysentery. There were no medical camps or clinics anywhere. While the Red Cross was of help to many in the war zones, there was nobody to help people fleeing from an invading army.

Expensive as well as cheap household articles, and clothes were left along the sides of the road. Expensive equipment like radios, fans, and small vessels were thrown away because people became weak as they walked more. You may have heard about jettisoning which means ships throwing away valuable cargo during an emergency like a violent storm. It was applicable to humans also during such a large-scale migration. The only valuable thing to carry was one's own life! All else became objects of little or no value.

On the second day I met another Indian of my age from Mysuru region (princely state of **Mysore** at that time). His name was Abdul Khader and like me he was the only son for his parents who lived in a village near Mysuru. We became very good friends and the conversations reduced the level of anxiety inside the mind. Abdul carried a black colored tin trunk box. At times, he carried it using his hands. At times, he carried it on his head. In addition he carried a small water bottle and a cloth bag containing a set of dresses.

He carried a copy of Quran and a book 'The Prophet'* by Khalil Gibran, a Lebanese poet. We discussed many things as we walked. I told him about Bhagavad Gita and how it was taught in a battlefield. Abdul told me about Ramadan and how it was followed. I was quite impressed by the system of Zakat, the annual donation to be given to any charity. He also shared a few things from the poems of Gibran. I still remember the quotation,

"The true wealth of a nation lies not in its gold or silver but in its learning, wisdom and in the uprightness of its sons".

[author - *(Please note Gibran was a Catholic Christian by birth and a mystic with a universal outlook. The Prophet in Gibran's book is more symbolic and an imaginary person.)]



Unfortunately, Abdul fell ill on the fifth day. It seemed to be malaria, and I could get some medicines for fever from some kind fellow travelers. We simply rested at some place for about three days. The life force in Abdul left little by little while I was a helpless mute witness. On February 26th 1942, Abdul died after three days of sickness. Taking help from a few other people, I dug a grave a few meters away from the road and buried him there. It was Maha Shivaratri day and I prayed for his soul.

A day before his death, he gave me the address of his parents and a letter with a couple of lines written. Along with this letter, he handed over his precious savings – five thousand Indian Rupees in cash which is a huge sum those days. (It is worth about 20 lakhs Indian Rupees as of 2026). He also gave me a small box containing 100 grams of gold. He requested me to somehow locate his parents and convey Abdul's love for his parents and hand over his life savings to them. Even today, I get goose bumps to think of that moment, dear! A dear friend was dying in my own arms, while I myself was not sure if I would live and reach India. There was so much money in my hands! Still it was absolutely useless in that place and in that time to save a human life!

After the day Abdul died, I walked for another 20 days to reach the Indian border in what is today's Manipur state. Eventually I reached my parents' home after another 3 weeks by various modes of transport. It was literally another new birth for me. There are no words to describe the joy of my parents to see me alive and back from the war zone. I lost half my body weight. My health was so bad that it took about a month to recover fully.

Once I recovered, I set out to locate Abdul's parents. It was not difficult to reach their home. But it was very difficult for me to communicate the news of the death of their only son. I shared their grief and consoled them as much as I could. Later in private, I called Abdul's father aside and

handed over the money and gold to him. After a couple of hours, I left after sharing my address in Puttur. After two weeks I received a letter from Abdul's father to come and see him in his village. This time I took a close relative along with me for any help needed there.

When we reached Abdul's home, it was comfortable to see both the parents were normal and composed. After the initial enquiries about health, Abdul's father brought a small metal box. It had the cash and gold given by Abdul to me in Burma. "Look Krishna, this wealth does not mean anything to me without my son. We have sufficient means to take care of our life till death. Abdul's mother and I were really surprised to meet an honest person like you. You are a total stranger to Abdul and all of us. There is no one who knows that Abdul handed over his life savings to you. You could have walked away with all that money and gold. Still you opted to locate us and completed your promise to our son. You are an honest young man with noble qualities just like my son Abdul. So, Abdul's mother and I have decided to hand it back to you. Please do any business or start an organization in the way you want. In your hands, this money will prosper and help humanity at large. In your success and growth we will see Abdul as an invisible partner. Please accept it with our blessings".

I got the shock of my life. I tried to resist and say "No". But they insisted.

Six months later, I started my furniture business in Mysuru. The entire investment money for this business was Abdul's life savings! I declared Abdul's parents as my foster parents and brought them to Mysuru. They were under my care for over a decade till they passed away. My parents also came and lived in Mysuru a few years later.

I, Krishna Rao, own very little and meagre as assets or possessions. Everything you see here – this house, the furniture, the car, are owned by the company and I pay monthly rent to the company. The company is owned by a trust managed by my sons and also a couple of wise people from the city. The profits are shared among the company staff and a portion is also donated to charities. You see...., I cannot forget the Burma Road littered with the possessions of fleeing people. All these objects, all these possessions, are ephemeral or temporary. We can enjoy them for a limited time, but we can never own them in the true sense.

Our possessions can get destroyed, or we must leave them with no other choice. Everything belongs to God. The only real friend is God or divine Mother. If there is a good reason, a person will survive all odds against him.

Some people call me a socialist, but that is incorrect. I stand for commercial enterprises and encourage profits. The word shareholders has a deeper meaning in my dictionary. That makes all the difference! There are many guidelines in the Bhagavad Gita relating to detachment from possessions, caring for welfare of society, and freedom from possessiveness and craving. I follow those guidelines as best as I can.

Please visit us whenever you have free time. We have several books that will interest you. The famous English writer R.K.Narayan lives three houses next to this house. Someday I will take

you to meet him also. You should get a copy of “Swami and Friends” and get an autograph from him. “

Krishna Rao Sir completed his story which was a fine example of the statement that “Truth is stranger than Fiction”. It was a memorable evening and I was gifted with lessons of life which are rare to receive as a first hand account.

Quote

The true wealth of a nation lies not in its gold or silver but in its learning, wisdom and in the uprightness of its sons.

Khalil Gibran

May all beings be happy!